Learning about Freemasonry, developing an understanding of it and taking part is central to our enjoyment of it. New members in particular have a need for learning and these needs fall into two parts.

1. What Freemasonry wants or expects them to learn, so that they can participate.
2. What they wish to learn about Freemasonry, to satisfy their own interests and motives for joining.

Experienced members also find that at different times in their membership they need to learn new things, especially as they approach the chair, become a Past Master, take on continuing office in a Lodge and, perhaps, become Metropolitan / Provincial / District or Grand Officers.

This document offers guidance for Lodges, to help them guide a new and existing member's learning in those aspects that Freemasonry wants or expects them to learn.

WHY LEARNING ABOUT FREEMASONRY IS SO IMPORTANT

- In recent surveys, new members expressed concern that there were not enough opportunities to learn about Freemasonry in their Lodges.
- In some cases this resulted in dissatisfaction, frustration and eventually to resignation.
- Those newer members who report satisfaction with the learning they receive about Freemasonry also tend to report greater satisfaction with and commitment to Freemasonry.
- Freemasons who have a good understanding of the Craft and their Lodge – of what we do, why we do it and how we do it – are better equipped to help their Lodges sustain their long-term future.

THE LODGE'S ROLE IN HELPING MEMBERS LEARN

- Many, but not all, members are self-motivated to learn about Freemasonry using their own resources and searches. Some started learning before they discussed possible membership.
- Personal Mentors can assist and encourage such self-motivated learning by following the guidance in "Personal Learning."
- It is important that Lodges guide members' learning from the earliest stages, to help them make sense of and understand what would otherwise be very peculiar and confusing experiences.
- This process can go hand-in-hand with mentoring, which is a different yet related process.
- Mentoring helps a new member to settle into the Lodge and into Freemasonry, and to progress in stages. It provides personal contact, support and encouragement.
- Guided learning is concerned with helping members learn about Freemasonry itself, so that they can understand it better, participate and gain more satisfaction.
- Guided learning may be offered or supported by the Personal Mentor, if they have the knowledge and experience required.
- In some Lodges it is offered or supported by a Lodge Preceptor, or by another member with a good understanding of the many aspects of the Lodge and of Freemasonry and with an empathy for and good rapport with new members.
- Some long-standing members of a Lodge may have forgotten what it is like to be a new Freemason, may take for granted their own learning and not appreciate how difficult it can be to develop an understanding of Freemasonry.

- Solomon, UGLE's online learning platform, is a very good start point for finding materials to use when educating members.

PREPARING FOR THE SECOND AND THIRD DEGREES

- A particular form of guided learning is helping a new member prepare for taking their second and third degrees.
- Start this by explaining that, following Initiation the new Freemason takes two further degrees, each of which conveys defined aspects of Freemasonry's precepts.
- Traditionally, before a working Mason could advance to the next degree, he would be tested on his competence in the current one.
- As speculative Freemasons, we continue this idea by asking candidates for the second and third degree to learn small pieces of ritual which comprise test "questions leading from the first to the second degree."
- For the Personal Mentor and Lodge Preceptor, this gives an opportunity to explain more about the meaning of each degree and its symbols.
- Once the new member understands what he is being asked to do and why, provide him with the words to the questions and follow the guidance in "Learning ritual" to help him learn.

TOPICS FOR A LODGE'S LEARNING PROGRAMME

- "Understanding" contains a list of information that a new Freemason will find helpful.
- The following are examples of topics that could form the basis of a learning programme for all members within a Lodge:
    - Understanding each degree ceremony (eg, its meaning, signs, tokens and words).
    - The symbols of Craft Freemasonry
    - The festive board, what we do and why
    - The history of the Lodge, including its practices and traditions
    - The offices in the Lodge, their duties and progression
    - The structure of Freemasonry in England & Wales
    - Regalia worn by Lodge members, including Provincial and Grand Officers
    - Wearing regalia, including collars and breast jewels
    - Personal and Lodge regalia
    - Freemasonry and its protocols
    - Forms of address in the Lodge, at the festive board and informally / socially
    - Visiting other Lodges
    - Practices at the festive board, including proposing and responding to toasts, firing, etc
    - Making a speech
    - How to learn and deliver the ritual
    - Contributing to the life of the Lodge
    - The Royal Arch and other Orders
    - Opportunities to be involved in the management of the Lodge.
- It is essential that anything delivered is accurate and up to date. Inaccurate information results in confusion and perpetuates myths. Sources should be checked before any new material is delivered.
- Sources for information include Solomon, the Members' Pathway Suggested Reading List, local guidance documents from your Province and your Lodge history.

- Further guidance on preparing a learning programme can be found in Solomon, especially in the area "Support and Promote Learning" and the sub-sections, "Introducing learning and development" and "Supporting learning and development".
- A special topic in its own right is "Learning ritual" and how to deliver it. Fewer people today know about rote learning, but thankfully we know more about how people learn.
- If any learning is to be delivered well, it has to be planned for and organised.

DELIVERING A LODGE EDUCATION PROGRAMME

- The topics above can be delivered to new members in a number of forms, including:
    - By an experienced member when accompanying a new member when the Lodge works a ceremony in a higher degree.
    - At a Lodge of Instruction.
    - At a study circle.
    - As a "nugget" during a Lodge meeting.
    - When helping someone to learn a piece of ritual.
    - Talks and seminars delivered by Provincial and other speakers.
    - Events organised by New and Young Masons Clubs.
- To save "reinventing the wheel", Lodge members who deliver this material could share their notes with each other as well as with the new members.
- Whenever delivering any of the above material, give new members the opportunity to ask questions. Interactive learning, in which the new member is actively engaged, is far easier to remember than passive learning, in which members are simply expected to absorb information.

WHAT NEXT?

Guided learning addresses what Freemasonry and the Lodge wants a member to learn. This is especially the case with new members, but not exclusively so. At other stages, such as when going into or coming out of the chair or when becoming a Provincial officer, Freemasonry expects members to learn new things that should not be assumed by more experienced members.

"Personal learning" addresses what the member wants to learn about Freemasonry.

Those supporting a member's learning are advised to provide a balance between satisfying both Freemasonry's need for guided learning and the member's need for personal learning.